Food on the Road

Garages, airports and long days in the car.

The system does not change when you leave your kitchen. The options get a bit worse, that is all.

01 The one rule
02 What to buy in a garage
03 The deli counter
04 The car kit
05 Airports and long days

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01

The One Rule

> THE RULE
>
> Decide where you are stopping and what you are getting **before you turn the key.**

A day on the road does not need a different system. You are doing the same thing you do at home, finding the protein anchor. Protein first, something green if you can get it, and the carbohydrate around the times you actually move. The options are worse, that is all.

The garage itself is rarely the problem. It is arriving at the garage with no decision made and an empty stomach, at which point the chicken fillet roll tends to make the decision for you.

So give it two minutes before you leave the house. Where am I stopping, roughly when, and what am I getting. A driving day with three decisions already made is a very different day to one with none.

What makes it easier

- **Try not to let the gap run past four hours.** Not for any metabolic reason. The guy who has not eaten since eight in the morning makes a fairly predictable decision at four in the afternoon.
- **The trap is usually the combination, not the food.** What catches us is the standard pairing - a roll, a pack of crisps, a full-sugar drink and a pastry with the coffee. That is a good chunk of your day's calories bought in ninety seconds, with about twenty grams of protein in it.
- **Same shop, different basket.** Shop a bit smarter in exactly the same garage and you can land fifty grams of protein for a third of the calories.

> *You are not looking for a healthy garage. You are looking for the protein in the one you are standing in.*

02

What to buy in a garage

Approximate protein per pack.

WHAT TO GRAB	PROTEIN	WORTH KNOWING
Deli turkey or chicken slices, 100g pack	20-25g	Goes with anything else on this list
Protein milk, 500ml	25-30g	Ninety seconds, no mess
Milk, 1 pint	20g	Usually the cheapest protein in the shop.
Greek yogurt pot	15-20g	Add some berries or a banana and you have a decent meal
Beef jerky or biltong, 50g	15-25g	Keeps for months, so it can live in the car.

Sushi pack	15-20g	A good option if it is there. Go easy on the sweet sauces.
Boiled eggs, pack of two	12g	Pairs with anything above to get you over 40g.
Protein bar	20g	Handy, but closer to a chocolate bar than we think

Two combinations that land 40g in under two minutes

— Protein milk and pack of deli slices. Roughly 40g

— A turkey pack and a yogurt, with a bag of popcorn if you want something to pick at. Roughly 40g, and it will hold you until dinner.

What quietly does the damage

— **The chicken fillet roll as built.** Loaded with butter and mayo it lands somewhere around 800 to 900 calories, with modest protein. Order with no butter or mayo and add lettuce, onion and tomato and it's a decent hit.

— **The meal deal.** The sandwich is rarely the issue. The crisps and the full-sugar bottle are.

— **The coffee stop.** A large latte and a pastry is a meal you did not count.

— **The smoothie bought instead of lunch.** Closer to a dessert than a meal, and you will be hungry again fairly quickly.

03

The Deli Counter

You can eat well at most delis. It is mostly in how you order, and none of it is awkward to ask for.

— **Ask for double chicken.** One portion is rarely more than 20g.

— **Go easy on the mayo and the cheese.** Between them they add a fair few calories without adding much to the roll.

— **Load the salad.** It is free, it fills the roll, and it is the fibre you are probably missing on a travel day.

— **If there is a hot counter, use it.** Chicken or beef with potatoes and vegetables is usually the better option.

— **Black coffee or an americano.** Milk and sugar is where the calories hide on a long drive.

04

The car kit

Set this up once and the road stops being much of a problem.

IN THE BOOT	WHY
A small cooler bag	Can bring a lot of the kitchen with you!
Greek yogurt	Sits in the cooler bag and gives you 15 to 20g with nothing to prepare.
Beef jerky or biltong	Keeps for months, so it is still there on the day you forgot everything else.
A shaker with two scoops in it	Add water at any garage and you have a good protein hit.
A big bottle of water	Mild dehydration can feel a lot like hunger.

Tupperware	Leftovers from a good meal the night before travel better than most of what you will buy.

> THE HONEST VERSION
>
> Do it the night before you know the driving is coming, and you will have covered most of what a travel day would otherwise cost you.

05

Airports and long days

Go to the airport full. Probably the most useful thing on this whole list, and it costs you nothing. A guy who eats properly before he leaves the house is far more resistant to the endless options once he is inside.

Airside

- Eggs, a chicken salad, a yogurt pot, sushi, a protein pot, protein bar, popcorn. Most terminals have a couple of these.
- Buy the big water after security and drink it before you board.

On the move all day

- **Plan the meal before you land, not after.** Arriving starving into a new city is where temptation takes over. Have a look at the menus of the places you know you will end up in and choose then.
- **Cabin air and air conditioning are drying.** Keep water with you and use the 'Thungry Test' before you eat. Drink 250ml, wait twenty minutes, and see if the hunger is still there.
- **Walk the terminal.** A long travel day can be eight thousand steps or four hundred, and it mostly comes down to whether you sit at the gate.

> AND IF THE DAY GOES SIDEWAYS ANYWAY
>
> Anchor the next meal and move on. No skipping the following morning to balance it, no punishment session, no starting again Monday. One bad day on the road is just a bad day. It only starts to cost you when every travel day gets written off, and that is a pattern rather than a day.
>
> *The day on the road is not really the problem. The day on the road with no decisions made is.*

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